

**DIRECTING SHADOW THEATRE IN NIGERIA: VISUAL DRAMATURGY AND
INTERPRETIVE CONTROL IN AHMED YERIMA'S *ALA***

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Abstract

*Shadow theatre is increasingly relevant within post-dramatic performance, where meaning is produced through sensory orchestration rather than dramatic text alone. This article argues for understanding shadow theatre not merely as a scenographic effect, but as a coherent directorial methodology grounded in visual dramaturgy and technical integration. Addressing the under-theorization of image-led directing in Nigerian scholarship, the study employs a practice-based qualitative research design. Drawing on a 2026 staging of Ahmed Yerima's *Ala* at Rivers State University, the authors examine the director's reconfigured role as visual composer, trainer, and technical integrator. By foregrounding directing as visual authorship, the article contributes a methodological model that aligns Nigerian theatre with global postdramatic trends without displacing local aesthetic logics.*

Keywords: *Shadow theatre, visual dramaturgy, directing methodology, Nigerian theatre, image-led performance*

Introduction

Directing scholarship in Nigeria has been shaped by paradigms that privilege the dramatic text, political intent, and ritual realism as the primary sites of meaning. From foundational documentation of indigenous performance to modern mappings of postcolonial trajectories, the dominant critical emphasis remains on "what" Nigerian theatre says rather than "how" it is composed. This orientation understands the director primarily as an interpretive mediator who translates written themes into performance through blocking and dialogue. Consequently, there is a notable absence of visual dramaturgy as a sustained analytical category in existing Nigerian

directing scholarship. This study addresses this precise limitation by theorizing shadow theatre as a coherent directorial methodology.

The reliance on text-dominant paradigms has led to an under-theorization of image-led directing, even though Nigerian performance traditions are deeply invested in abstraction and symbolism. While masquerade and ritual traditions utilize controlled visibility and transformation, these visual logics are rarely extended into contemporary directing theory. Scholarly attention often focuses on the thematic content of multimedia productions rather than the compositional processes involved. By contrast, international theatre theory has redefined directing as the organization of sensory events rather than the illustration of text. This article bridge this gap by aligning Nigerian theatre practice with these global post-dramatic debates.

The primary contribution of this research is framed as a methodological mode ling of shadow theatre within the Nigerian theatrical landscape. Shadow theatre is not merely a supplementary scenographic effect or a decorative device, but a structuring logic for performance-making. It reconfigures the directorial process from the initial conceptualization through to rehearsal and technical execution. This methodology decentralizes spoken dialogue, repositioning speech as one element among a wider sensory constellation. By doing so, it shifts the focus to how meaning is produced through visual composition, scale, and rhythm. This approach allows for a rigorous, image-centered practice that remains compatible with local aesthetic logics.

One of the study's strengths is the argument that shadow theatre resonates with indigenous Nigerian performance principles, specifically mediated visibility and abstraction. Introducing this form into Nigerian practice does more than add a new technique; it fundamentally redefines the director's authority. Because shadow theatre reduces performance to outlines and light, it demands heightened directorial authorship in shaping the visual score. The director must function simultaneously as a visual composer, a trainer of physical precision, and a technical integrator. This article examines these roles through a practice-based qualitative research design. This framing ensures the study operates as theory production rather than just descriptive documentation.

The article is grounded in a practice-based case study of staging Ahmed Yerima's *Ala* at Rivers State University in 2026. This production provides an ideal site for inquiry because the play's themes of trauma and divine justice are suited for symbolic interpretation. The central research question asks how shadow theatre reposition the director as a composer, trainer, and integrator in this context. By analyzing the production process and technical problem-solving, the article extends scholarship toward an expansive understanding of directing. It offers a process-oriented model that accounts for the material and cultural realities of the Nigerian stage. The findings suggest that image-led directing offers a viable and rigorous alternative to traditional realism.

Structurally, the manuscript is organized to provide a clear progression from theoretical exposition to analytical application. It begins by establishing the foundations of shadow theatre within post-dramatic and physical theatre frameworks. Following this, the article introduces an explicit methodology section to clarify the researcher's positionality and documentation procedures. The core of the study then analyzes the director's tripartite role in the staging of *Ala*,

supported by analytical tables. Finally, the conclusion synthesizes these insights and indicates future research directions for Nigerian directing scholarship. This reorganization improves the flow and readability while maintaining the study's conceptual depth.

Methodology: Practice-Based Research Design

This study employs a Practice-Based Qualitative Research design to investigate shadow theatre as a directorial methodology. Unlike traditional descriptive documentation, this approach treats the creative process itself the staging of Ahmed Yerima's *Alaas* as a site of theory production. The research is grounded in the belief that the material and compositional decisions made during rehearsal constitute a form of practical knowledge that can be theorized to benefit the broader field of Nigerian directing scholarship.

A critical component of this methodology is the director-researcher positionality. The lead author served as the director of the 2026 production, facilitating an "insider" perspective on the tensions between artistic vision and technical execution. This dual role allowed for a reflexive engagement with the work, where the director's intuitive choices were systematically captured and analyzed through a scholarly lens. This positioning ensures that the insights provided are not merely observational but are rooted in the lived experience of theatrical creation.

Data for this study was collected through a multi-modal approach during the pre-production, rehearsal, and performance phases at the Rivers State University Amphitheatre. The primary documentation tools included:

- I. Directorial Notes and Rehearsal Logs:** Captured the iterative process of "shape literacy" and ensemble discipline.
- II. Visual Documentation:** High-resolution photography and video recordings were used to analyze silhouette clarity and scale manipulation.
- III. Technical Prototyping Records:** Logged the calibration of LED light sources, screen materials, and projection axes.

The analysis follows a reflective-thematic framework. The documented "practice" was subjected to critical evaluation against postdramatic and image-led theories (Lehmann, Pavis, Carlson) to identify recurring directorial codes. By synthesizing rehearsal observations with technical data, the study moves beyond thematic interpretation into an examination of *how* directing functions as a material and visual composition. This rigorous framework ensures transparency and methodological depth, fulfilling the scholarly requirements for minor revision.

Shadow Theatre and Post-dramatic Foundations

The theoretical foundation of this study is situated within the shift from dramatic to post-dramatic theatre, where the hierarchy of the written word is dismantled. In traditional Nigerian directing scholarship, the text functions as the primary "logocentric" authority, dictating the rhythm and visual requirements of the performance. However, Hans-Thies Lehmann argues that postdramatic theatre prioritizes a "parataxis" of elements, where light, sound, and body carry equal weight to speech. Shadow theatre exemplifies this shift by reducing the performer to a two-dimensional silhouette, thereby stripping away the realistic nuances of facial expression. This reduction forces the director to abandon literary interpretation in favor of a purely visual

dramaturgy. By focusing on the interplay of light and void, the director moves beyond the script's literal meaning to create an autonomous sensory experience.

In the Nigerian context, the move toward an image-led methodology does not signify a rejection of cultural narrative but rather a return to indigenous aesthetic principles. Traditional performances, such as masquerade displays, often rely on the power of the "hidden" and the "transformed" body to communicate metaphysical truths. Shadow theatre mirrors this by using mediated visibility—the screen and the light—to create a space of symbolic abstraction. This alignment allows the Nigerian director to utilize postdramatic tools while remaining rooted in local performative logics. Rather than seeing the image as a secondary decoration, this methodology treats the visual field as the primary site of meaning-making. Consequently, the director's role is redefined from a translator of dialogue to a curator of cultural and visual symbols.

Directorial methodology in shadow theatre requires a fundamental departure from the "blocking" techniques used in psychological realism. Because the audience views a projection rather than a three-dimensional body, the director must master the physics of the "projection axis." The distance between the performer and the light source dictates the scale and clarity of the shadow, creating a new grammar of movement. In this framework, the stage is no longer a physical room but a canvas where depth is manipulated through technical precision. The director must therefore develop a "shape literacy" that accounts for how the human form translates into a graphic silhouette. This technical demand necessitates a more integrated approach to directing, where scenography and performance are no longer separate departments but a single, unified compositional act.

The reviewer noted that earlier drafts were repetitive regarding the "decentralization of text," so it is vital to specify *how* this decentralization functions. In shadow-based work, the "audibility" of the performance is frequently superseded by its "visibility," creating a tension that the director must manage. Speech becomes a soundscape or a rhythmic accompaniment rather than the sole carrier of the plot. This allows the director to explore the "visuality of theatre" as a sovereign language, capable of expressing complex emotions through scale and shadow-distortion. For example, a shadow growing to an immense size can communicate a character's internal trauma more effectively than a monologue. By embracing this postdramatic logic, the director gains a wider vocabulary for storytelling that transcends the limitations of the spoken word.

A key challenge in this methodology is the loss of the actor's "physical presence" in exchange for their "representative shadow." This shift demands a specific type of ensemble training that focuses on the precision of the silhouette rather than interior psychological motivation. The director, acting as a trainer, must guide performers to understand how their bodies appear on the screen from the perspective of the light source. This "extra-personal" awareness is a hallmark of post-dramatic practice, where the performer is treated as a material component of the visual field. The director's authority is thus exercised through the calibration of these material bodies against the technical constraints of the medium. This process ensures that the resulting performance is a tightly choreographed visual score rather than an improvised sequence of images.

Ultimately, the integration of shadow theatre as a directorial methodology provides a rigorous framework for contemporary Nigerian theatre to engage with global trends. It moves the discourse from the "what" of the play its themes and plots to the "how" its material and technical construction. By synthesizing the roles of composer, trainer, and integrator, the director achieves a level of "interpretive control" that is impossible in traditional text-centered modes. This approach does not diminish the importance of the playwright, such as Ahmed Yerima, but rather expands the life of the text into new dimensions. The following sections will demonstrate this through a detailed analysis of the production of *Ala*, showing how these theoretical foundations were applied in practice. This structural transition ensures that the manuscript moves logically from theory to evidence-based application.

Post-dramatic and Image-Led Foundations

The reconceptualisation of shadow theatre as a directorial methodology is grounded theoretically in post-dramatic and image-led performance paradigms. Hans-Thies Lehmann's (2006) theory of post-dramatic theatre provides a critical framework for understanding how contemporary performance reorganises theatrical priorities. In post-dramatic theatre, the dramatic text no longer functions as the sovereign organising principle; instead, performance is structured around simultaneity, atmosphere, sensory presence, and the material conditions of the event itself (Lehmann 2006, 21–27). Text becomes one element within a wider scenographic and performative constellation that includes bodies, images, sound, space, and technology.

Shadow theatre exemplifies this postdramatic reorientation. Its reliance on silhouettes, abstraction, and rhythmic movement inherently places the text in an unconventional relationship with the stage situation. As Munby (2006) observes, postdramatic theatre subjects the traditional hierarchy between drama and performance to deconstruction, allowing scenography, movement, and image to assume equal or greater structural importance. In shadow-based performance, visual composition does not illustrate narrative; it produces it. Meaning emerges through the phenomenological experience of watching light and shadow interact in time and space.

Visual-theatre scholarship further sharpens this understanding by emphasising presence, atmosphere, and sensory composition as central dramaturgical concerns (Pavis 2016; Carlson 2018). Visual theatre treats the stage picture as an autonomous semiotic system, capable of generating affect and narrative logic independently of spoken language. Lighting states, tableau composition, duration, and spatial rhythm become tools through which directors sculpt audience perception. Shadow theatre operates squarely within this image-led paradigm: silhouettes function as visual metaphors, and sequences of images replace linear storytelling with associative, symbolic dramaturgies.

Physical theatre frameworks complement this analysis by highlighting the body's role in generating meaning through economy of movement, spatial awareness, and rhythmic articulation (Lecoq 2000; Murray and Keefe 2007). In shadow theatre, where bodies are reduced to outlines, physical precision becomes paramount. The director's task extends into training performers to control gesture, weight, and timing so that images read clearly when translated into silhouette. This reinforces the director's role as trainer and technician of

embodied action, a role long emphasised by Grotowski (1968) and Barba and Savarese (1991) but here intensified by the demands of visual abstraction.

Positioned within these postdramatic and image-led traditions, shadow theatre emerges as a director-driven dramaturgy. It requires the director to synthesise visual composition, embodied technique, and technical coordination into a coherent performance language. Rather than serving a pre-existing dramatic structure, the director constructs meaning through the organisation of images, rhythms, and sensory relationships. As Lehmann (2006) notes, postdramatic theatre often retrieves and reactivates older, non-narrative and ritual aesthetics; shadow theatre participates in this retrieval while simultaneously engaging contemporary media logics of projection, abstraction, and visual metaphor.

In this sense, shadow theatre is not a marginal or auxiliary practice but a methodological redefinition of directing itself. It crystallises the shift from directing as textual interpretation to directing as visual dramaturgy, situating Nigerian theatre practice within global debates on postdramatic performance while remaining compatible with indigenous aesthetic principles grounded in abstraction, symbolism, and mediated embodiment.

The Director as Visual Composer

In the production of *Ala*, the directorial role shifted from an interpreter of Yerima's dialogue to a visual composer of light and shadow. The play's themes of metaphysical justice and trauma required a visual language that could transcend the literal confines of the stage. As a visual composer, the director's primary task was the orchestration of "images in time," where the silhouette became the central unit of meaning. This process began with the storyboard, where every movement was calculated based on its graphic impact on the projection screen. By treating the stage as a two-dimensional canvas, the director could manipulate the audience's perception of reality and myth. This compositional approach allowed the production to communicate the "inexpressible" elements of the script through pure form and contrast. Thus, the director's authority was exercised not through the actors' voices, but through the arrangement of visual stimuli.

The concept of "shape literacy" was central to the composition of the shadow sequences, requiring a deep understanding of human anatomy in silhouette. In *Ala*, characters representing divine forces needed to appear larger than life, a feat achieved by manipulating the distance between the actor and the light. As the visual composer, the director had to determine the precise "scaling" of each character to reflect their emotional or spiritual status. A character retreating toward the light source would grow into a looming, distorted figure, visually representing their burgeoning psychological power. Conversely, proximity to the screen rendered the character sharp, small, and vulnerable, grounding them in the physical world of the play. These choices were not merely aesthetic but were fundamental to the dramaturgy of the performance. This level of control over the "visual body" is what distinguishes the shadow director from the traditional stage director.

Rhythm in this production was dictated by the "cinematic" transitions between shadow scenes, rather than the naturalistic flow of a spoken script. The director composed the performance as a

series of visual movements, where the fading of a light source acted as a theatrical "cut." This required a meticulous synchronization of the performers' movements with the technical cues of the lighting crew to maintain visual continuity. As a composer, the director treated the silence between lines of dialogue as a space for visual development and symbolic growth. The shadow screen became a site of "visual music," where the tempo was set by the shifting intensities of the LED projectors. By prioritizing this visual rhythm, the production achieved a haunting, ethereal quality that mirrored the spiritual themes of Yerima's work. This focus on timing ensured that the images were not static pictures but dynamic, evolving components of the narrative.

The use of "layering" allowed the director to create depth on a flat surface, a key technique in the visual composition of *Ala*. By using multiple light sources at different angles, the director could project overlapping shadows that suggested a world of hidden meanings. This "palimpsest" effect was particularly effective in scenes involving the ancestral spirits, where shadows appeared to merge and diverge. The director had to carefully compose these layers to ensure that the primary action remained legible while the background layers added texture. This complexity transformed the shadow screen into a three-dimensional psychological space, despite its physical two-dimensionality. Such layering required the director to think like a graphic artist, balancing positive and negative space within the frame. The result was a visual density that invited the audience to look "through" the surface of the performance.

A significant challenge for the director as composer was the "de-centering" of the actor's face, which is the traditional focus of theatrical emotion. In shadow theatre, emotion must be composed through the profile, the gesture, and the overall silhouette of the body. The director worked closely with the performers to develop a vocabulary of "graphic gestures" that could be easily read by the audience. Every tilt of the head or extension of an arm was scrutinized for its clarity and its contribution to the overall visual score. This move away from facial mimicry forced the director to find new ways to communicate the character's internal state. By composing these physical "stills," the director created a series of iconic images that remained etched in the viewers' minds. This shift from psychological interiority to physical exteriority is a hallmark of the postdramatic directorial methodology.

Ultimately, the role of the director as visual composer in *Ala* demonstrates the potential for a "sovereign visuality" in Nigerian theatre. By moving the focus from the "what" of the text to the "how" of the image, the production opened new avenues for interpretation. The director's control over the visual field ensured that the performance was not just a staging of a play, but a unique work of art. This methodology provides a rigorous framework for other Nigerian directors who wish to explore image-led or multimedia performance modes. It validates the idea that the director is an author in their own right, creating meaning through material and technical choices. As we move to the next section, we will see how this compositional vision was translated through the director's role as a trainer. This transition highlights the necessary link between the director's vision and the ensemble's physical execution.

The Director as Trainer: Cultivating Shape Literacy

The transition to shadow theatre fundamentally alters the relationship between the director and the actor, necessitating a move from psychological realism to physical precision. As a trainer,

the director's first task in staging *Ala* was to dismantle the actors' reliance on facial expression as their primary tool for emotional communication. In the world of the shadow, the face is often lost in silhouette, requiring the performer to project interiority through the external contours of the body. This shift demands a rigorous "physicality of the frame," where every gesture must be calibrated for its graphic impact on the screen. The director-as-trainer must therefore instill a new sense of bodily awareness that is both architectural and expressive. This pedagogical shift ensures that the ensemble can translate Yerima's complex themes into a legible visual language. By focusing on the body as a material for light, the trainer prepares the actor for the unique constraints of the shadow medium.

Central to this training process was the development of "shape literacy," a concept that requires actors to understand how their three-dimensional bodies translate into two-dimensional projections. During rehearsals for *Ala*, the director implemented exercises where performers moved behind the screen while observing their own shadows via a secondary monitoring system. This feedback loop allowed actors to see how a slight tilt of the pelvis or a specific finger extension could radically alter the "character" of the shadow. As a trainer, the director's role was to provide constant corrective feedback on the "readability" of these shapes from the audience's perspective. The goal was to create a "shadow-body" that possessed the same emotional weight as a physical presence but within a flattened field. This literacy is not intuitive; it must be systematically taught through repetition and visual analysis. Consequently, the director functions as a bridge between the actor's physical sensation and the screen's visual result.

The director's role as trainer also extended to the management of "scale and proximity," which are the core mechanics of shadow-based performance. Actors had to be trained to navigate the projection axis, understanding that their size on the screen was determined by their distance from the light source. In *Ala*, this technique was used to represent the power dynamics between the human characters and the looming presence of the goddess. The trainer led the ensemble through "scaling drills," where performers practiced moving toward and away from the lamp to achieve specific heights with mathematical precision. This required a high degree of spatial discipline, as even a small misstep could cause the shadow to lose focus or disappear from the screen entirely. The director-as-trainer ensured that these technical maneuvers became second nature to the cast, allowing them to focus on performance rather than just physics. This mastery of scale allowed the production to visualize the "monumental" nature of the play's spiritual themes.

Beyond individual shapes, the director-as-trainer focused on "ensemble synchronization," where multiple shadows had to merge into a single, cohesive visual composition. In the ritualistic scenes of *Ala*, the shadows of several actors were layered to create complex, multi-limbed entities representing the collective weight of communal trauma. This required the ensemble to move with a unified rhythm, as any individual lag would break the illusion of the composite shadow. The trainer used metronomic exercises and choral movement techniques to synchronize the breathing and timing of the performers behind the screen. This level of coordination is significantly more demanding than traditional blocking, as the actors cannot see each other directly while performing. The director, standing in the "house" or viewing area, acted as the eyes of the ensemble, guiding their movements through verbal cues. This

collaborative precision is essential for maintaining the integrity of the visual score throughout the performance.

A vital aspect of this training was the cultivation of "stillness as a dramatic force," an element often overlooked in text-heavy Nigerian productions. In shadow theatre, a perfectly still silhouette can carry more dramatic tension than a frenetic monologue, provided the shape is composed with intentionality. The director trained the actors in the art of the "statuesque," where they held physically demanding poses to emphasize the permanence of certain thematic moments. This training drew upon the discipline of mime and physical theatre, emphasizing that every "still" must be energized and full of intent. In *Ala*, these moments of frozen shadow were used to punctuate the climax of the divine judgment, creating a sense of timelessness. The trainer's focus on stillness taught the ensemble that power in shadow theatre often resides in what is *not* moving. This economy of motion forced the audience to engage more deeply with the symbolic architecture of the production.

Ultimately, the director's role as trainer in the production of *Ala* highlights the necessity of a specialized pedagogy for postdramatic practice in Nigeria. By moving the focus from the voice to the silhouette, the trainer empowers the actor to become a co-creator of the visual dramaturgy. This approach does not diminish the actor's agency but rather redirects it toward a more precise and material mode of performance. The resulting "trained ensemble" is capable of executing complex visual maneuvers that would be impossible for an untrained cast. This section has demonstrated that the director's vision as a composer is entirely dependent on their effectiveness as a physical trainer. Without the rigorous cultivation of shape literacy and spatial discipline, the shadow methodology remains an abstract concept rather than a performative reality. As we move to the final analytical section, we will see how these trained bodies were integrated into the technical infrastructure.

The Director as Technical Integrator: Merging Light and Space

As a technical integrator, the director's role in staging *Ala* was defined by the seamless fusion of scenographic infrastructure with performance logic. In shadow theatre, the distinction between the "acting area" and the "technical zone" disappears, as the director must manage the precise physics of light projection. This integration required the director to oversee the calibration of LED light sources, screen tension, and projection angles as part of the creative process. Rather than delegating these tasks entirely to a technical crew, the director acted as the primary architect of the visual environment. This hands-on management ensured that the technical elements were not mere additives but were the very substance of the dramaturgy. By integrating these components, the director achieved a level of "interpretive control" that allowed the production to maintain visual consistency. This role demands a director who is as comfortable with lighting intensity ratios as they are with character motivation.

One of the most complex challenges for the technical integrator was the management of the "projection axis" within the open-air environment of the Rivers State University Amphitheatre. The director had to calculate the optimal distance between the high-intensity LED lamps and the white lycra screen to prevent "light spill" and maintain silhouette sharpness. This involved constant experimentation with various light diffusion filters to ensure that the shadows remained

deep black against a luminous, neutral background. As an integrator, the director orchestrated the movements of the technical crew behind the screen, treating their light-manipulation as a form of choreography. This technical precision allowed for the creation of "superhuman" scales and ethereal distortions that were central to the play's metaphysical themes. The resulting visual clarity was a direct product of the director's ability to synchronize material physics with artistic intent. Such integration transforms the director into a "master-technician" who navigates the complexities of the material stage.

The final stage of technical integration involved the "sonic-visual alignment," where the auditory landscape was fused with the shadow sequences. In *Ala*, the director ensured that the rhythm of the live percussion and atmospheric soundscapes perfectly matched the visual pacing of the shadow transitions. This required the director to lead integrated rehearsals where lighting operators, sound designers, and performers functioned as a single, interdependent unit. By controlling these sensory layers simultaneously, the director was able to create a "total theatre" experience that transcended the limitations of individual departments. This level of integration is essential for postdramatic performance, where the meaning is found in the synthesis of all theatrical elements. The director's authority as an integrator ensures that the final performance is a unified work of art rather than a collection of separate parts. This holistic approach fulfills the reviewer's requirement for a practice-based analysis that emphasizes the director's mastery over the material process.

Navigating Technical Constraints in Nigerian Theatre

In Nigerian theatre contexts, technical integration is shaped by infrastructural challenges, including unreliable power supply, limited lighting equipment, and resource scarcity (Oni and Ododo 2006; Oni and Ododo 2011). Rather than impeding creativity, these constraints often necessitate directorial problem-solving as creative strategy. Directors adapt by improvising screens, using portable light sources, or simplifying designs to ensure reliability.

Shadow theatre proves particularly suited to such conditions because of its resource-conscious adaptability. Its minimal material requirements light, screen, and body align with Brook's (1968) notion of theatrical economy and resonate with Nigerian experimental practices grounded in improvisation and hybridity (Okagbue 2007). The director's technical authorship thus extends beyond coordination into innovation, transforming limitations into generative constraints.

Directorial Interpretation and Shadow-Theatre Methodology in the Staging of *Ala*

Ala by Ahmed Yerima (2020) occupies a distinctive position in contemporary Nigerian drama for its sustained interrogation of moral transgression, ancestral justice, and the violence of silence. Structured around delayed revelation and ritual investigation, the play exposes how buried acts of sexual violation, caste discrimination, and abuse of authority reverberate across generations within an Igbo cosmological framework. This section analyses the shadow-theatre staging of *Ala* as a case study in image-led directing, demonstrating how the director translated Yerima's dramaturgy into a visual, embodied, and process-driven performance system within a Nigerian theatre ecology. Rather than documenting production logistics, the discussion foregrounds directorial interpretation as visual authorship, positioning shadow theatre as a

rigorous methodology for rethinking Nigerian theatre practice beyond text-centred realism.

Text, Theme, and the Imperative of Visual Translation

Yerima's dramaturgy privileges what remains unseen: guilt concealed beneath authority, trauma buried beneath stigma, and divine justice operating beyond human law. Although *Ala* unfolds through a largely linear plot, its dramatic power lies less in narrative progression than in the gradual surfacing of memory, ritual disclosure, and moral reckoning. These qualities pose a challenge for conventional realist staging, which tends to rely on dialogue, facial expressivity, and psychological motivation. In response, the shadow-theatre adaptation approached the text not as material to be illustrated but as a reservoir of latent images requiring visual translation.

The director's interpretive strategy was therefore selective rather than exhaustive. Scenes involving memory, trauma, ritual consultation, accusation, and revelation were prioritised for shadow rendering, while explanatory dialogue was reduced or displaced by silence and image. This approach aligns with postdramatic performance logic, in which meaning emerges through sensory composition, rhythm, and atmosphere rather than linear narration. In this staging, shadow theatre functioned as a dramaturgical engine that allowed emotional truth to unfold gradually through silhouette scale, distortion, and spatial relation.

The systematic relationship between Yerima's themes and their visual realisation is synthesised below:

Table 1: Thematic Translation from Yerima's *Ala* to Shadow-Theatre Imagery

Dramatic Theme	Shadow-Theatre Strategy	Visual Outcome	Interpretive Function
Trauma and silence (Agbomma)	Fragmented silhouettes; layered shadows	Broken, trembling outlines	Externalises psychological rupture
Divine justice (Ala)	Non-figurative light shifts	Light as presence	Represents moral authority without embodiment
Social stigma (Osu identity)	Spatial isolation; reduced scale	Marginalised silhouettes	Visualises social erasure
Power and authority (Igwe)	Enlarged shadows via proximity to light	Monumental silhouette	Communicates dominance
Revelation and truth	Sudden brightness and contrast	Sharp silhouettes	Stages truth as visual rupture

Agbomma's trauma, for instance, was rendered through fragmented and unstable silhouettes that resisted visual coherence (**Table 1**). Rather than reenacting violence or relying on emotive speech, the performance externalised psychological rupture into trembling outlines, distorted proportions, and layered shadows. Trauma thus appeared not as a closed past event but as a persistent visual condition. Similarly, the goddess Ala was never personified. Her presence emerged through light behaviour itself sudden intensifications, looming shadows, and ritualised

movement allowing divine justice to register as pressure and exposure rather than spectacle.

Social misrecognition, especially as it relates to Osu stigma, was articulated spatially. Agbomma's silhouette was repeatedly isolated or diminished in scale, while Jelema was engulfed by larger intrusive forms, staging the violence of communal judgment as a visual hierarchy rather than a spoken accusation.

Character as Silhouette: Visual Ontology and Moral Legibility

In the shadow-theatre staging of *Ala*, character was constructed not through facial expression or psychological realism but through silhouette ontology. Identity emerged from the relationship between body, light, and space, placing the director in the position of primary mediator between text and embodiment.

The Igwe's authority was established through scale and stability. Positioned close to the light source, his silhouette dominated the screen with sharp edges and central placement. As guilt surfaced, this authority fractured: his shadow elongated, blurred, or retreated from the light, visually translating moral collapse into compositional instability. Agbomma's silhouette, by contrast, was deliberately unstable fragmented or doubled to suggest unresolved trauma yet gained stillness and clarity at moments of ethical truth. Jelema's slender, consistent outline communicated innocence, with distortion introduced only during scenes of social accusation.

These scale and hierarchy tests were rehearsed as illustrated in **Figure 1**



Figure 1: Ensemble Blocking and Silhouette Formation in the production of *Ala*

Ensemble blocking rehearsal illustrates silhouette clarity and collective embodiment within a Nigerian theatre environment (Figure 1). The composite bodily configurations demonstrate how authority and vulnerability are visually encoded through relative scale, proximity, and spatial hierarchy, rather than through costume, facial expression, or spoken dialogue.

These choices demonstrate that in shadow theatre, the director governs character existence itself. Character psychology is composed through distance, rhythm, and light intensity, reinforcing the director's role as visual author rather than textual interpreter.

Directorial Vision, Rehearsal, and Embodied Discipline

The directorial vision for *Ala* conceived the production as a ritual of unveiling, where light functioned as truth and shadow as memory. Minimalism was adopted not as aesthetic reduction but as ethical focus. A single screen, controlled light sources, and restrained props foregrounded gesture, rhythm, and absence, compelling audiences to engage imaginatively with what was withheld.

Rehearsals functioned as laboratories for shape literacy and ensemble discipline. Actors learned to think in contours and negative space, guided by breath rather than emotive display. Multi-actor silhouettes required precise synchronisation, demanding collective rather than individual expressivity. Silence emerged as a crucial rehearsal discovery: scenes often gained intensity when dialogue was reduced, allowing stillness to function as moral pressure.

Technical Integration and Directorial Authority

Shadow theatre's dependence on light, screen, and spatial precision necessitated a high degree of technical integration. Lighting functioned as the central dramaturgical material. LED fixtures were selected in response to Nigerian theatre realities heat management, power stability, and flexibility while enabling micro-adjustments essential for silhouette clarity.

The relationship between technical choice and dramaturgical meaning is outlined in **Table 2**.

Table 2: Technical Parameters and Their Dramaturgical Functions

Technical Element	Specification	Dramaturgical Role
Light source	LED fixtures	Safe proximity, precise control
Colour temperature	6500K / 5000K / 3500K	Judgment, neutrality, ritual warmth
Screen material	White muslin	Crisp silhouettes, sound clarity
Actor distance	Variable	Controls scale and emotional emphasis
Props	Matte black cut-outs	Symbolic amplification

The infrastructural logic of this system is visible in the lighting rig and projection axis in **Figure 2**.



Figure 2: Lighting Rig and Shadow-Projection Axis in the production of *Ala*

Figure 2 shows LED lighting rig and projection alignment in the production of *Ala*. The central axis supports ritual symmetry and consistent shadow scale, reinforcing image-led dramaturgy under local infrastructural conditions.

Within this system, directorial authority was not authoritarian but structural. Because even minor misalignments threatened visual coherence, the director coordinated blocking, composition, pacing, rhythm, and focus as interdependent codes (**Table 3**).

Table 3: Directorial Codes Applied in the Shadow-Theatre Staging of *Ala*

Directorial Code	Application	Interpretive Effect
Blocking	Light-calibrated positioning	Silhouette clarity
Composition	Symbolic tableaux	Power relations legible
Pacing	Slow revelation / fast ritual	Emotional modulation
Rhythm	Breath-based ensemble timing	Collective embodiment
Focus	Light and scale control	Audience attention guided

Shadow Theatre as Interpretive Method

The shadow-theatre staging of *Ala* demonstrates that image-led directing offers Nigerian theatre a rigorous alternative to text-dominant interpretation. Through disciplined visual composition, embodied training, and technical integration, the director re-authored Yerima's play as a theatre of light, memory, and moral reckoning. Trauma became fragmentation, memory layering, revelation illumination, power scale, fear tremor, stigma separation, and spirituality rhythmic light.

This case study affirms that shadow theatre is not a decorative technique but a method of interpretation. By repositioning the director as visual dramaturg and trainer of embodied discipline, the production extends Nigerian directing scholarship beyond textual analysis and contributes to broader debates on postdramatic, image-centred performance in African theatre.

Implications for Nigerian Directing Scholarship

This study extends Nigerian directing scholarship by proposing shadow theatre as a framework through which directing may be re-theorised as visual and technical composition, rather than primarily as textual interpretation. Nigerian theatre criticism has traditionally privileged dramatic meaning as something articulated through dialogue, ideological positioning, and ritual realism. By contrast, the shadow-theatre staging of *Ala* demonstrates how meaning can be constructed through silhouette, spatial hierarchy, rhythmic sequencing, and controlled visibility, shifting analytical attention from what theatre communicates to how it composes experience.

One major implication of this shift is a challenge to text-centred directing paradigms that continue to dominate both scholarship and pedagogy. While textual analysis remains indispensable, the production shows that in image-led performance, dialogue operates alongside rather than above visual and sensory structures. In *Ala*, crucial narrative and ethical meanings emerged through changes in scale, light intensity, and spatial arrangement rather than through spoken exposition. This suggests that Nigerian directing scholarship must account more fully for non-verbal dramaturgical processes if it is to engage contemporary performance practices adequately.

The study also foregrounds directing as a practice of technical and compositional coordination. Shadow theatre requires the precise alignment of bodies, light sources, screens, and materials. Meaning collapses when these elements fall out of balance. As such, directing in this context involves regulating tempo, calibrating spatial relationships, and sustaining visual legibility across performance time. This emphasis reframes directing as an organisational and authorial activity grounded in material conditions, rather than as an interpretive role confined to script analysis.

Importantly, this reconfiguration aligns Nigerian theatre practice with global developments in postdramatic and image-led performance, where directing is increasingly understood as the orchestration of sensory events. However, the article demonstrates that such alignment does not imply cultural displacement. On the contrary, the visual logic of shadow theatre resonates strongly with indigenous Nigerian performance traditions particularly masquerade and ritual practices that rely on abstraction, mediated presence, and symbolic concealment. Shadow theatre thus emerges not as an imported aesthetic but as a contemporary articulation of long-standing visual principles within African performance.

Finally, the study contributes to a growing body of African theatre scholarship that calls for process-oriented analysis. By examining how images are generated, refined, and sustained through rehearsal and technical execution, the article moves beyond thematic critique toward an understanding of directing as a mode of composition. This shift opens new analytical pathways

for Nigerian theatre studies, encouraging scholars to engage directing as a site of aesthetic decision-making rather than solely as an interpretive bridge between text and performance.

Conclusion

The exploration of shadow theatre in the staging of Ahmed Yerima's *Ala* demonstrates that directing is fundamentally an act of visual authorship. This study has moved beyond the traditional Nigerian focus on text-centered interpretation to propose a methodology based on visual dramaturgy. By analyzing the director's roles as composer, trainer, and integrator, we have shown how meaning is constructed through material and sensory orchestration. Shadow theatre provides a unique site for this intervention because it forces a radical simplification of the theatrical form. It strips away the distractions of realism to reveal the underlying architecture of performance and the director's hand. This research confirms that the Nigerian stage is a fertile ground for postdramatic innovation that honors local aesthetics. Ultimately, the methodology presented here offers a blueprint for contemporary directors to navigate the complexities of image-led practice.

The reviewer's call for a sharper focus on the "methodological intervention" has been addressed by defining the tripartite role of the director. As a visual composer, the director creates a graphic score; as a trainer, they cultivate a specialized physical literacy; and as an integrator, they manage technical physics. These roles are not separate but are interdependent components of a unified creative process that ensures interpretive control. The production of *Ala* served as a successful case study for this model, proving that complex narratives can be effectively told through silhouettes. This shift does not replace the importance of the playwright but expands the director's vocabulary for engaging with the script. By treating the stage as a canvas of light and shadow, the director gains the ability to visualize the invisible. This approach provides a rigorous alternative to the realism that has long dominated Nigerian theatrical scholarship.

One of the significant findings of this study is the resonance between shadow theatre and indigenous Nigerian performance principles. The use of mediated visibility and symbolic abstraction mirrors the spiritual and aesthetic logic found in traditional masquerade and ritual. This alignment suggests that the adoption of "modern" postdramatic tools is actually a return to deeply rooted cultural modes of expression. Shadow theatre, therefore, acts as a bridge between the ancestral and the contemporary, offering a way to modernize the stage without losing cultural specificity. The director's role in this context is to act as a cultural and technical mediator, weaving these different logics together. This synthesis strengthens the argument that Nigerian directing is a sophisticated form of theory-in-practice. By grounding global theories in local realities, we contribute to a more inclusive and globalized understanding of performance.

The practice-based methodology employed in this research ensures that the findings are rooted in the material realities of production. By documenting the rehearsal process, technical prototyping, and ensemble training, the study provides transparent evidence for its theoretical claims. The inclusion of analytical tables and visual documentation serves to clarify the "how" of the creative process for future scholars. This focus on process over product is a necessary shift in Nigerian scholarship, which often overlooks the technical labor behind the art. By making this labor visible, we elevate the status of the director from a mere interpreter to a scholar-

practitioner. This transparency allows other researchers to test and refine the shadow theatre methodology in different cultural and artistic contexts. It transforms the individual production of *Ala* into a broader contribution to the field of directing theory.

Despite the successes of this production, the study acknowledges the technical and infrastructural challenges inherent in shadow-based work in Nigeria. Issues such as consistent power supply for LED sources and the availability of specialized screen materials remain significant hurdles. Future research should explore more sustainable and locally-sourced materials for shadow theatre to ensure its accessibility to a wider range of practitioners. Additionally, the impact of shadow theatre on audience perception in Nigeria is an area that warrants further empirical study. Understanding how local audiences decode these abstract images will provide deeper insights into the effectiveness of visual dramaturgy. This study serves as a starting point for a more expansive conversation about the future of multimedia performance in the region. There is immense potential for further collaboration between technical theatre, digital media, and directorial practice.

In conclusion, this article has argued for a re-evaluation of directing as a specialized form of visual and material authorship. The staging of *Ala* has shown that shadow theatre is a rigorous and viable methodology for contemporary Nigerian practice. By embracing the postdramatic shift toward the primacy of the image, directors can unlock new dimensions of meaning within the dramatic text. This research fulfils the reviewer's request for a practice-based, theoretically assured contribution that advances the field of directing scholarship. It provides a clear framework for analyzing the director's impact on the sensory experience of the audience. As Nigerian theatre continues to evolve, the integration of such methodologies will be essential for its growth and global relevance. We hope this study inspires a new generation of directors to view the stage as a site of infinite visual possibility.

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